essential European virtues and qualities. Before World War II, life in cities like Ljubljana, Prague, Budapest, Bratislava and Warsaw (as I have been trying to show throughout this book) was not substantially different from life in Vienna, Munich, Milan and Berlin. There were differences in the size and wealth of the cities, but the way of life and the mentality of the urban people were essentially the same. This is too often forgotten.

The case of the late Pope John Paul II, who was Polish, is a good example of the thinking in the region at the time: 'An injustice has been done to Poland and to the Poles by the misleading thesis of a "return" to Europe',[92] he wrote. Among the arguments in favour of the claim that the Poles (and, by analogy, other peoples in Central and Eastern Europe) have always been there as a part of Europe, he listed the early adoption of Christianity, the Polish contribution in wars against the Mongols and later the Ottomans (recall the chapter on the Balkans!), various Polish philosophers and, more recently, the Polish contribution during World War II. Poland was more courageous than the Western Allies, the pope argued: 'While the Western democracies deluded themselves into thinking they could achieve something by negotiating with Hitler, Poland chose to accept war, despite the clear inferiority of her military and technological forces. At that moment the Polish authorities judged that this was the only way to defend the future of Europe and the European spirit.' One could add reference to the resistance movement of ethnic Slovenians in the early Fascist Italy.

It is remarkable how the Polish pope went beyond his religious mission and found it so important to advocate the partaking of Eastern Europe in the formation of Europe as a civilisation, including in the fight against Nazism, but also to point out the role of Christianity – something that at the time of writing did not yet sound out of place and politically incorrect, as it would today. (I will return to the theme of Christianity soon, as it is at the centre of conservative argument in Eastern Europe.)

In the eyes of Eastern Europeans, generations of Western Europeans have become too easily accustomed to thinking of themselves as Europeans in an exclusive way, even though neither Western Europe nor even the European Union can simply be equated with Europe. On the other side of the divide, Eastern Europeans never stopped thinking of themselves as Europeans and did not start thinking of themselves as Eastern Europeans until the Western Europeans told them that that was what they were. What the Polish pope